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Alex Petropoulos & Ben Carrey

Alex and Ben are the drummer and bassist respectively in Pigeons Playing Ping Pong, a self-described band that jams. They've gained a loyal following by constantly touring the U.S., and recording original tunes that balance musical hooks with creative improvisation.

Alex and Ben were interviewed via Zoom on March 8, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe. I'm very pleased to have Ben and Alex with me today from Pigeons Playing Ping Pong. And I had the pleasure of talking to Jeremy and Greg earlier and told them that I had just seen the oddest video of pigeons actually playing ping pong.

AP: Yeah. What's almost weirder than the name is the fact that it was actually a real thing. First people assume it was just some made up nonsense and then you find out about the actual experiment. It's still pretty much nonsense but it's a little more realness to it.

MR: Was it called — well B.F. Skinner was a Hamilton College graduate.

AP: No way. Wow. Look at that.

MR: Where I'm Zooming from. Yes. Yeah names are funny you know, like if the band becomes successful then it's a good name.

AP: Yeah. I mean I'm sure they might have mentioned it but at the time it was more so just them doing acoustic little duo sets so it was, hey we need a name, here's some funny alliteration and things stick.

Ben: I remember having friends a few years into it, they're like, "You guys need to just go by 'Pigeons' like Pigeons Playing Ping Pong's a little goofy." And I'm like, "It's Pigeons Playing Ping Pong that's just what it is." And like you said, if it succeeds then it must have been a good name.

MR: Ben, were those two guys together for a while and then they recruited a bass player?

Ben: Sort of. They were an acoustic duo freshman year actually I played a gig or two with another band, actually with the guitarist who ended up recording our first album at the university radio station, that was at UMUC — I forget the name of it, but it was at College Park. So I played a few shows, saw them play a couple of times, and then I moved off campus sophomore year and they were still on campus and they needed a place to jam. They brought a drummer friend from Jazz History of Rock class I believe and they came over to my house to jam and they didn't have a bass player, so, that's how it happened.

MR: Were you a bass player in high school?

Ben: I started — I picked up a bass for the first time at my friend's sixteenth birthday party when he got a new bass, and I was like this is cool. And he let me play his bass at his birthday party for like the whole time and I was just smitten.

MR: What kinds of tunes would smitten you that you would hear on the radio because of the bass part?

Ben: Well the one he taught me was the incorrect bass line to "Smoke on the Water" the one that follows the guitar chords.

AP: It's always the first song anyone ever learns.

Ben: Yeah but the real bass line is [scats] so my first thing I learned was actually wrong. But he also, a year or two before that, introduced me to the Red Hot Chili Peppers. I was looking for a CD to buy at Borders Books and Music which no one under the age of whatever will remember even existed, but he showed me Red Hot Chili Peppers Greatest Hits and I burned that CD out basically.

MR: Because — what's the guy's name, Flea?

Ben: Flea. Yeah. He's another first name bassist. That's sort of where I got my inspiration from.

MR: I see. Well I'm going to ask a question of both of you — I think sometimes certain kinds of personalities are attracted to certain instruments. Alex, do you agree with that? I mean drummers are usually — fill-in-the-blank?

AP: Oh man. You know I think for me it was definitely — which doesn't apply to all types of drums but definitely kind of the slightly more like physical approach to it and you know, kind of more of a visceral, you know that kind of the physical side of it I guess kind of always appealed to me. I mean I started at such a young age. I started taking lessons when I was five and I grew up, you know, very active, bouncing off the walls, also with sports and activities I was just kind of always on the run and always kind of boppin' around. So I don't know if that kind of played into the more percussive side of my personality. I know, you know with a lot of people there's a lot of trial and error with different instruments. You know my brother and sister, they're both great musicians and they bounced around and tried a bunch of different instruments. I kind of just always had that kind of initial reaction to the drums and kind of, you know the feeling and kind of the physical aspect of it and that rhythm kind of percussiveness to it, that just kind of naturally appealed to me. Yeah.

MR: Were there drummers that you paid attention to? Inspired you?

AP: At an early age it was definitely more of, you know, a product of what I was hearing with my parents obviously, a lot of like classic rock, you know, a lot of drummers like Keith Moon, John Bonham, the classics that you hear, but a lot of guys like you know Richie Hayward from Little Feat and, you know, a lot of guys that, you know, really held down

that pocket for me, you know. The flashy side is great too and you know you have guys that crush on all aspects to it, but just a lot of it was just those guys, you know, there was just those really good strong backbeats. And initially it led to different styles and kind of me diving down different roads and different styles and that brought about a whole new interest to me, but you know that classic rock vibe kind of initially is what appealed to me and, you know.

MR: How about you Ben? I don't know if we can make a generalization about bass players, but traditionally they're not, they don't spend a lot of time in the spotlight.

Ben: Yes. Traditionally they don't. I think for me I didn't really thrive in that spotlight. I remember the first time I played on stage with the Pigeons, I believe it was like our first, at least our first gig in a real music venue at the Recher Theater in Towson. I was standing there basically like kind of rocking side to side, expressionless, just like so focused on playing, nervous to be heard or seen by anyone, even when I first picked up bass at home I would keep the volume in my room really low. I didn't want my family hearing it, I was just very shy about it, versus I feel like some guitarists are like, you know, the fall forward mentality is just like let's go at it and, you know, make it happen. I was very I don't know if it's protective of my progress or like how I wanted to approach it, but yeah, I guess a little shyer at first. I've sort of been able to come out of my shell a little bit thanks to Pigeons and sharing the stage with all those guys.

MR: How much of the bass lines you conceive and play — I'm trying to figure out how to ask this question — are actually connected to the chord symbol and the scales that might go with it? Do you think that way or are you more of an ear player?

Ben: Well I started out much more of an ear player, and just sort of taking the same shape over different root chords, so I learned from my bass teacher, Dave DeMarco, the blues pentatonic scale and just kind of threw that shape over everything. I actually started on piano so I learned, you know, the Suzuki method and you know scales a little bit on piano so when I put it on bass I saw it as more of a pattern rather than the notes on a piano. And I overlayed it a bit in my head but I got a lot of mileage out of just taking that same shape and either taking that minor third and making it major, you know, taking the flat seven and tossing a minor sixth on it here and there, and applying that pattern to my ear and then over time, especially with some parts that Jeremy has written, understood more about how those scales are interacting and how to lead between different chords. So it sort of started out as a lot more ear and a lot more single pattern with small little adjustments here and there and then I've sort of been coming at it from the other end, trying to bring that knowledge of theory together, to put that together.

MR: Alex, you joined the group when?

AP: 2016. Yup.

MR: And had you heard them beforehand?

AP: I had a little bit, not too much actually. I had seen them once or twice in college coincidentally, the college band I played in our guitarist grew up with Jeremy. So he brought us to his hometown and we opened for Pigeons once when I was in college, and that's kind of where I really met them, and that was fun, that was a small little show in Hartford.

Ben: Good pizza.

AP: Yeah. Pizza. And then yeah, I went to school in Hartford, Connecticut, you know played in kind of the northeast, New England area. Never full time as my full-on profession. And you know about a year after school I was still working in New Haven, going to New York on the weekends to play and zipping back to Connecticut to work and kind of doing the whole back and forth. And it was fun, it was draining, it was a lot but it was nice to finally get a random phone call from Jeremy, you know, "Hey I don't know if you remember me, you know, we hung out —" And I had remembered him but you know we hadn't spent too much time together and it all kind of fit in nicely when it all happened. I went down there and auditioned a few times and it went pretty smoothly. Yeah.

Ben: I can tell that from the three of us we tried out two different drummers before that and we were like okay, it's not our old drummer like chemistry might take some time to build back up. And we were at Greg's parents house in Long Island and Gator came in. I think we were 30 seconds to a minute into the first song, which I believe was "Time to Ride" and the three of us without even really looking at each other just shared the understanding like this is — we're good. Like we have a future now. It was almost instantaneous the way we connected and understood that this was going to be — we were going to be fine thanks to Gator.

MR: That's really curious that it became apparent so quickly. Can you be specific why?

Ben: There's just a language you build up with the people you play with for a while and we played with Dan since they jammed at my house for the first time in '08. You know many shows earlier — I don't know how many shows we were playing a year when Gator joined but we were upwards of 180 shows a year at one point in 2012-2013. Still a lot once Gator joined but just that much time with someone I called it the ESPN with me and Dan. You know it's like ESP, that's the funny name I used for it. But there is some aspect of that connection that I don't know if Gator picked up on what we were together and he just blended in nicely or he had just some energy that tapped into that same thing. It just felt like you were conversing fluently right away musically speaking.

MR: Alex, do you remember if it was a big decision to quit your day gig?

AP: It was. You know music from a young age was always my biggest passion. I, you know growing up I had great teachers, I got to study with the great Dave DiCenso who is an

amazing world-class drummer professor at Berklee. I'm from up in New Hampshire. He lived pretty close by so I was able to study with him, Jeff Harrington, another great drummer up there. So I always kind of had that passion like music was it. I also always had that underlying fear of if it doesn't work out not having any sort of back-up plan and kind of that's how I was raised is kind of that analytical kind of side. I'm always planning for the future. And while I always knew it was my biggest passion I did kind of fear that well hey, if it doesn't work out I don't know what the heck I'm going to do. So you know I kind of toyed with that and now after school, after college finished you know I was playing —

MR: Hold on one second. That was my fault are you still there? Okay we'll just snip that out.

AP: Yeah. So you know after college ended I kind of did have that big decision you know. I was in a position where I was playing enough shows to get by but it was a big grind and I kind of wanted to just set myself up for a little bit more of a future so that if I did want to go for it again I kind of had a little more stability in my life. Of course right when I got settled with that job I got the call. So it was definitely a sign and you know I've always had a very, I've always been pretty competitive kind of stubborn guy so in that sense of when I was given that chance I really just in my mind was not going to let it get past me. And I've had a lot of great preparation. Now one thing with that drummer Dave DiCenso I always, well part of our lessons was that he would even have a section where he would give me some material to learn and part of our lesson is I would show up as if it was a big audition for a group. And he would sit there at a table like and I would perform, he wouldn't say anything you know it wouldn't be like — and then afterwards you know he'd be like you know, tell me whether I got the gig or now you know what I mean? He'd give me any songs from "Pretzel Logic" Steely Dan, to Bishop Trotter and the Holy Spirits gospel music, and you know every lesson it was like I was showing up for this big audition. And I think that trained me a lot to kind of, you know, just different prep for different styles. Because even Pigeons, as much as you know now it's my heart and soul you know, at the time even their style of music, it was an adjustment for me. It wasn't necessarily something that I grew up always playing and specifically technique-wise with kind of the more four on the floor dance grooves and kind of just the rhythmic structure of the music was an adjustment. So I kind of saw it as a great opportunity that I just didn't want to take any chance of letting get by so it worked out.

MR: If either of you met someone who didn't know what you did and then you tell them I play in a band and they say, "What kind of music do you play?" Do you have an answer for that?

AP: You know I think our official answer for a while was high energy psychedelic funk music, which is still — you know as long as the band name is as far as a description. You

know it's one of those things where it is always changing you know. Ben I'm sure explains it differently as Jeremy and Greg would. It's all encompassing, but you know it really does cover a lot of ground. Typically I'll kind of say you know it does have that improv sense — you know we do a lot of improv in our set which is kind of tied with the rock/funk aspect kind of gives it — you know along with our production, our big lights, it kind of adds like that psychedelic atmosphere where it's a full on production, it's a full on show. And so while it's always changing, you know, high energy psychedelic funk/rock is, you know, morphing. Ben could probably add a little —

MR: Ben, yeah, you get three words to describe it.

Ben: So I would go, especially early on I would say three words specifically — energetic psychedelic funk. What I would also do is I would just bring in bands that people would be familiar with, I would say kind of like if Phish, Red Hot Chili Peppers and Talking Heads had a baby with George Clinton.

AP: Yeah, that's funny, two out of those three bands I often com — I say a lot of the time it's like a Chili Peppers meets Talking Heads.

Ben: With like Phish jamming.

AP: And a little bit of like Pink Floyd.

Ben: Oh Pink Floyd, yeah. I meant — so it was, I think I did Pink Floyd, Talking Heads, Chili Peppers. Maybe I left out Phish. I think it was Pink Floyd, Talking Heads, Chili Peppers.

AP: That sounds like a good —

Ben: With George Clinton conducting.

MR: Conducting.

AP: Not to say we're at that echelon.

MR: But neither one of you would default to just say oh we're a jam band? Is that correct?

Ben: I always used to say we're a band that jams. The categorization of jam band, to me often is, aside from like the big kahunas — you know it's guitar solos, you know a lot of just meandering this or that. We're a band that has our own style and substance and approach both from a stage presence perspective and from a songwriting perspective and just from the energy of what we put out, but we do take our songs on a lot of sonic journeys. A lot of times we have done full sets of just improv, a few times throughout, and we incorporate that into every show we do.

MR: I'm glad you used the word "meandering" because I've heard jam bands or been in jams that it seemed to be yeah we're just meandering here. And I don't hear that from you guys. I hear this balance of experimentation but form at the same time like there's an intent going on there when you build things up and you all seem to get this sense like time to move on, time to change. And that's very listenable.

AP: Yeah I think that's important. And you know going back to you know jam, obviously a lot of genres at their basic terms are so convoluted. You know rock doesn't nearly you know tie in progressive metal with you know some sort of other — jazz, everything, there's such a wide array. And I think jam is almost even more of like a kind of convoluted term in the sense where if we're talking about jam being improv or kind of on the spot playing then isn't jazz technically the same thing in a lot of senses. There's a lot of rock bands with improv, there's a lot of — and even if you look at the jam scene, you know you look at a jam band flyer and there could be — for a festival — and there's bands that are like basically metal bands that incorporate improv and then there's reggae bands that incorporate improv and then there's us which is kind of more that rock dance funk side. So like you said I think one important thing is that we do kind of like to have some sort of intent and theme. And I think a lot of it goes with you know we play long concerts. You know it's typically two 75-minute sets plus an encore so when you do have a lot of material and a lot of jams or improv sections you know things can get lost if they're kind of treated just as a let's just let things go free. While it is fun to play without those walls and just be free, when you are kind of in a setting like that where you're also trying to you know captivate the audience for such a long period of time, and you know I think there definitely — it's beneficial to have some more intent and structure within those jams.

Ben: But I think the structure of our set list design changes every night, Jeremy works really hard constantly working on how things would go together then checks in with us, we check back in, we have ideas, we put out song ideas. Spending all that time ahead of the show and throughout the weeks and months and years that we've been playing allows me to get into the moment and know where we're going with it and allows that space you know when you have constraint in certain ways like this is where we're going, this is where we are. We have the freedom to really explore and not be afraid like are we just meandering but like what are we really doing here. We know what we're doing with it and we've learned a lot of different moves that it's like okay go from the two to the five or you know the five to the one, back to the two. We kind of keep those modal things in mind as we build things back up and just have kind of learned what works from a very general standpoint with the crowd versus just us like bringing people into the moment together.

MR: In your business what does it mean to be the headliner?

AP: I mean I guess if you're just on your own a lot of the times we'll do group tours or if there's a tour of different bands you know. We've been lucky enough to headline our own tours in the sense that, you know it's our show, we'll bring along an opener or a local support, but it's typically, it's a lot of time to kind of fill and produce a show every

night and those headline tours are — you know it's a lot of work like Ben just mentioned, it's a new set list every night and when we return to the city from the last time we'll bring up that set list and make sure we're not repeating material. Because we're also fans of music. We realize that a lot of fans of bands might only get a couple of chances to see a band they love. Maybe once a year, maybe once in their life. So we've been part of great group tours as well. You know we're going to be on an upcoming tour with a couple of other great bands, Andy Frasco and Dogs in a Pile where it's co-headlining where you'll kind of split the —

Ben: That's what he looks like.

AP: Oh yeah, there you go. You kind of split the main event but you know those tours where we have been lucky enough, which is most of our tours, to kind of headline a tour it's, you know it's a lot to kind of keep things fresh and it keeps us on our toes. It's fun for us as well to go in and start a new journey each night.

Ben: And to add to that, to me a headline in our business most literally means that you're the headline of the marquee. Your name is at the top. So you know you bring out bands, you're just headlining whatever that would mean, I think Gator says what it means to us but —

MR: Do you always play last?

Ben: Yeah, when we headline.

AP: Typically, yeah.

MR. Yeah. I just recall, I was in the rock business in the 80s and we would get excited that we were going to open up for any number of people, Rick Derringer or that kind of thing. And more often than not it was a drag. The people weren't there to see us. We often times felt the sound man was making us sound not too good just in case — but do you ever get the sense that your audience is tired out after, you know you're the third band? I mean when I look at your videos it looks like the flock is not tired out.

AP: Yeah. No I mean I think a lot of it is a product of that kind of our general scene is that ever since I started seeing shows kind of in that rock/jam scene, you're typically in for a marathon of a night you know. And it's definitely a battle. There's definitely times where we'll adjust the set. You know if we'll get towards kind of mid-second set and you can kind of get a vibe that people might be tiring out a little bit. Or if we're playing more typically they're full two-set shows, but if we're playing on a Wednesday and we happen to be in Tacoma or you know Midwest or out west where we might not be a major market, we might still have a great crowd but we'll maybe choose to do one long set instead of providing a set break. So we're always cognizant of the fact that, you know, we're putting on a production and a show. And while we want to have the freedom on stage to kind of just do our thing, you know, it's definitely important to take into account,

you know, the show you're putting on. Maybe not doing as an extended of a low dynamic jam later in a show you know. Maybe not follow-up such a large peak with a more of a ballad type tune later. You know it's — like most musicians would shape their set lists but we typically on the fly even adjusted stuff or called audibles just to kind of — we're always kind of aware of putting on the best show and leaving people wanting more but also our — kind of one of our big things is kind of like beating people down with the music so that afterwards they're like wow — all right we got it all. You know it's riding that fine line.

Ben: Yes. Satisfied but wanting more.

AP: Yeah.

MR: I recently I was able to do an interview with a drummer named Ed Soph who was one of those guys who played with everybody but also a legend in the jazz education world.

AP: Nice.

MR: And we were talking about time with bass and — bassists and drummers. And I'm just going to read a short quote from him: "I've played with bass players and the first tune I go oh God this guy really plays behind the beat. So what I do is I go with that bass player and lock up at the slower tempo. Now there can be a problem. If I go down to where he is he continues to slow down, that's a problem. Just like a bass player who plays on top and when you join him he wants to take off again." Is there such a thing as, for you two, as playing on top of the beat or behind the beat?

AP: Absolutely. You know I think Ben could attest to that you know. We have a lot of you know variety of kind of sounds we're pulling from and you know we have a lot of uptempo dance beats where you know I think a big part of our sound is, you'll hear the term "four on the floor" where you know, for anyone not aware it's more of that constant kind of [scats] kind of — a lot of what Ben and I will do with this group is we really will kind of provide those bass blocks and within those bass blocks, yeah, there's a lot of times where with our more uptempo stuff we're definitely pushing it. And then if we're playing more of a dub or reggae effect or even just a slower tune I think that's definitely something we'll dive into as far as feeling. And then on top of that I think a big part of our sound which me and Ben do pretty well at is working with dynamics and just volume control and you know taking those peaks and valleys and bringing it down and being more subtle when it needs to be to let the guitars shine. I think in any genre but particularly with bands who do a lot of improv, you know, one thing I think that can get very easily overlooked is kind of those volume dynamics and, you know you could be ripping up there and you could be super locked in but if everything is just kind of just here the whole time without those feel changes or without those volume changes it can get very stale. So like you said, kind of choosing where on the beat to lie, holding things

— while I agree with that quote, that's a great point you know. You could adjust to one guy and then they might adjust to your adjustment and you know it's definitely something to be aware of. But I think both feel and dynamics are something that you know Ben and I will try to really focus on to allow the other guitars and vocals to shine. And we'll take our moments too but typically it's that strong base.

Ben: One of the advantages of playing with the same person for so long, before we start recording we jokingly introduce us, like jazz players will meet each other for the first time after playing, we kind of know, like I know when Gator's really going to drag into something. I know when it's coming and then when he goes into it how to sort of respond to complement that. The other guys know how to respond to that as well and you know just being, instead of having to find who to lock into we sort of all lock around a central groove and tempo and unit that we share going forward so one of us can be in front, one of us can be behind, both of us can be behind, both of us can be in front, but the four of us sort of know where that's at and are letting that lead the way rather than any individual player.

MR: Do you have stage monitors usually that are — the sound that's coming out of it includes your own instrument?

Ben: Yeah.

AP: Yeah we all run on our own individual mixes but we do use in-ear monitors and we have a great sound guy that we have our mixes all dialed in. Typically I'll definitely want drums in there just more for the visceral kind of feeling of playing and feeling everything. A lot of what I take is bass and then just for reference guitar and vocals just as far as just to have a more of a pleasant general mix. But my mix is mostly honed in on the rhythm aspect and just — you know I've — it's tough because as musicians you know on one hand you want what you're hearing to sound like mixed well — almost like an album where everything is like great.

Ben: What the audience is hearing out front, yeah.

AP: Right. I over time have kind of realized what's more important to me providing a good show and that's more hearing the bass and drums and then just kind of trinkets of what I'll actually you know need. Enough of what that will make me comfortable and be able to stay in the pocket. And then a lot of groups will use talkback mics and stuff or different ways to communicate, we've generally kept ours just organic with just we have little signals here, you know, as you're well aware because you play with the guys, little wide eyes could even easily tell someone hey, you know, bring it down, what are you doing.

MR: Yeah. The look.

AP: Yeah. The look. So we all run our own mixes but I assume they're all pretty similar in the sense of we take what we need to get dialed first and then we'll kind of bring in —

Ben: Yeah. What we need is different. For me one of the struggles I've had over time is, especially when we all build up really loudly in jams, hearing when Greg, our rhythm guitarist, is switching keys or like moving maybe up a progression, and so I've had to make sure to dial that in while still not having too much of it like when he goes into his wah to kind of overwhelm things. So our monitor guy, Mike, also will do some adjustments during and listening to the mix just like our front of the house sound guy does but of course he's trying to do that to four mixes. He'll mute our vocal mics in jams to keep things a little cleaner. I have my guitars split a little bit so I have a little bit more of Jeremy on the right, a little bit more of Greg on the left, so that I can distinguish what they're doing. But again, it's not ideal. I wouldn't really want to hear it with the guitars always split in one direction or the other. It probably helps a little bit with the stereo imaging and having the sound poke through better in a venue, but for me it's just purely can I tell what's going on and then when I want to know what it sounds like I listen back to the recordings on those afterwards and critique our overall sound that way. But when I'm in the moment it's just making sure I'm performing my part appropriately.

MR: It's very common to be watching a band and you see one of the musicians look offstage at the monitor person and they point to the monitor and then they go like this right? People hardly ever point to the monitor and go like give me less. It always just seems like more, give me more.

Ben: That's why you want to start less and add it from there. Because if you start with too much then you're losing the feel of the room too. So, and in those moments you just want to make sure you can hear it. So I do kind of get that but that is —

AP: No one else probably wants to see a fellow musician point to them and go down. Like uh oh.

MR: Both those guitar players.

AP: Everything down.

Ben: I have a couple of signals I mean for my bass, I just go up and down. Greg when he wants his vocals turns to Mike and goes up or down. And then I have Jeremy's guitar one, Greg's guitar two and so up or down, which is just a very simple quick thing, just go down or up. And then the same with their vocals too Jeremy is this up, Greg is this up or down. And that's just very simple, I can do it quickly, I can do it like — I don't have to be like hey what's up, like this and that. And —

AP: Well I think it's important. Like maybe it's just me but I mean I remember growing up if I ever went to a show it's like I'd almost feel like I have like this allegiance to like if I'm seeing them in my home town I'm like I want these musicians I love to like love this

venue. So like if I were at a show growing up and I would see, you know, a member frustratingly be like, I'd almost be like oh no, I hope they like — you know it's funny — so I do think it's important to be subtle with your signals in general or kind of be as smooth as you can because like there's no denying that if you ever, you know, see someone kind of — you're always like uh oh.

Ben: For some reason —

AP: There are some guys who talk in the mic, "Hey could I get a little more" — that's the worst.

Ben: Yeah. And you can have a talkback for that too where you could just go to a mic and say something to your monitor guy. That's another advantage of talkback. But it brings to mind our old like — it was at a show, it was an outdoor venue somewhere in Pennsylvania. And I forget who it was but it was like some world renown keyboardist and he was dealing with the house crew and they were sound checking but it was at a festival setting so it was outside and everyone was watching them sound check which is one of the worst parts about being a musician or an audience member is just sitting there watching a live check, a public sound check. And the guy couldn't figure out how to turn down the keys and the monitor and it was really loud. So the keyboardist just held down a key and just pointed down. He didn't like touch it — he was just like [one-note long tone] and I was like, just hearing that I'm like oh God. But that keyboardist is like we've got to fix this and like I don't care. And you know I think that's not the way I'd approach that but to each his own.

MR: Yeah. Well I noticed you were doing your hand signals with your right hand which means you could sort of keep playing with your left hand, right? With your bass line?

Ben: Yeah. I really try to avoid doing that while playing. I'll try to find a moment in it. The one signal I really need is if the wah is coming in too hot, which we've been able to really — Mike's only been with us for a few months now but we've already dialed in to a point where he knows what to listen for and change it. But if Greg's wah just comes in my ears in a certain hotness I just go like this real quick and he just knows to bring that down. Because that's just the wah. And that's the only thing I really need to know, if we're in a heavy jam and I'm losing Greg a little bit then I'll kind of look and do a quick thing like that but most of the adjustments are in between songs or like when there's a break or a moment aside from things that are like, you know, hey make sure that we're in the screaming jam that I can hear Jeremy's guitar a little bit. Or like it's just sort of stuff that like makes sense to adjust over time, just like the front of the house sound guy knows to turn up the guitar in a certain moment, Mike knows when to adjust for me. But yeah I am able to do it pretty quickly and not have to like point — him up and down — it's just like boom. And actually before we got Mike I printed out a little sheet, a laminated sheet that

had my signals on it for the house monitor guy at a festival. I'm like, "Here, put this right there and then you'll know what my signals are."

MR: Nice.

Ben: Because they don't know what I like or what I don't like but if I can give them a signal that made it easier and just allows me to focus more on the show and not worry am I going to just lose it.

AP: A good sound crew is huge.

MR: Reminds me of a story of Bob Rosengarden the drummer told me working for the first time with a bass player and he's looking at the bass player and he's going like this and the bass player says, "You want me to play louder?" And he goes, "No, play better." You guys could use that.

Ben: Yeah I'm glad you didn't learn that a few years ago.

AP: I won't start using that.

Ben: Yeah. You've had many opportunities over the years.

MR: There's sort of an old fashioned term at least around here, called a train wreck where a gig, everything just seems to go awry. And I wonder if — we sometimes put them out of our minds, but do you guys have any memories of particular train wrecks on a gig?

AP: You know as far as like a regular just touring, headlining gig or a festival gig, nothing comes to mind as far as like oh gosh like things just seem to keep getting worse. One kind of funny thing, which fortunately in the end you know it never really ended up being too much of a thing is we did get asked to play like a small awards show one time at a local college of like the Maryland Music Awards. And we were asked to do one of the performances during the award show, which they cut to, in a live performance. So we went in for a full day of rehearsal and they had the full media crew there, all the spots, you know, all the signals you know. They're going to call you, when you start we're going to have all your amps on the settings they need to be, everything's going to be boom. They point to you, you go, you play your three minutes, you're done. So the rehearsal went pretty great you know. We weren't super comfortable in that environment, we're used to much more you know free flowing, not as much time constraint. It's hard enough to get one of our songs down to three minutes let alone perform in that environment. So we did it, it was all good. And then we got to the actual award show, cut to us. I don't even think any of the amps they put out were like plugged in let alone on. Like everything was just like — so I remember I started. And it was one of those situations where the drums were playing a groove, I'm just like oh no, I can see them playing but I don't hear anything. So I'm like I hope to gosh that everyone in the crowd is hearing something. Maybe my monitor is just out. Then you see Greg [looks] at the other

guys that are trying to keep it together but you know something is going on. So you know the first minute of our three minute song was just [scats].

MR: Drum solo.

AP: So people are like wow, this is a hell of a drumming show here. So you know I can remember, and like I said out of any situation, it wasn't our show, it was — you know typically we're not even, that's not even really our vibe in general is like the award show type thing and the quick performances. But I do remember after that one we all kind of just got off stage and just kind of went our separate ways and like, "See you guys at practice tomorrow." And to be honest it really wasn't even on us. We were very prepared. So that's the only one. I'll still drive past that college campus and I always have a good laugh.

Ben: Oh that's funny.

AP: You know there's Goucher College, home of the worst gig.

Ben: I completely forgot about that. I must have put it totally out of my mind. When you first said train wreck I thought boy, for a musician, for a band, if a train hits a cow that's a train wreck for the cow but the audience on the train isn't going to even notice. They're just moving along. So a train wreck as a band is often we're just obliterated and just parts are flying everywhere and we're like oh my God that went so bad. And then the audience who's riding on the train, it's just like I didn't even feel anything.

AP: I will say to that point there have been a few shows where, not in a train wreck scenario but like anyone there's shows that afterwards resonate with you more than others, so there are some that you're like, I don't really think we're quite feeling it tonight. And it is weird, those few shows whenever that happens we'll go on our fan page or something, or on our website or something and every comment is like, "Show of the year!" That was the one. Like we played recently at Caverns which was like a blast, like it was still a great show, but I remember it was one of those ones where afterwards you know sound-wise, playing-wise we were just like ick, you know that could have been. And you know the first thing you see is like, "Show of the year by Pigeons, Caverns." And you're just like oh gosh. To your point, that happens.

Ben: Well everyone has their own — we're on stage and our sound guys are looking at these walls of the cave that are just blasting off the high frequencies and it's just like I hated it, I had a horrible time. I thought the low end in there was kind of cool so what I was focusing on is like, well that part of it at least worked for me.

AP: Well sound, but even also the playing-wise I mean, I remember us not thinking it was our tightest. And people are like, "You've got to listen to the Caverns."

Ben: Well another thing that brought to mind when you started with that extended drum solo at the award show is when we were at Red Rocks.

AP: Oh yeah.

Ben: We're playing that big show.

AP: Arguably the coolest venue in the world.

Ben: Yeah. And apparently every few months the power just cuts out in the middle of a set.

AP: The whole town power surges.

Ben: The whole town of Morrison, a power surge. So we are in the middle of a song, we're in the middle of a chorus of "Water" [sings] Water — boom. Everything cuts out. We look over, we're like what's happening, you know what's going on. Gator just keeps playing, so he goes into a drum solo. We go over, we talk to our monitor guy who was filling in at the time. He's like, "They told me the power for the city is out." And I look over and I'm like, "All right, let's get up on the drum riser and start playing drums with Gator." And you just get up there and do this extended drum solo thing. My go-to move in those situations is just hitting the cymbal [scats] just like slowly bringing it down.

AP: Typically when that happens there's always that glorious moment of it popping back on and crowd reaction is great. That one was two and a half minutes in where I'm just like, I'm at the point where I can hardly play anymore. Without any sound I'm also trying to play as loud as I possibly can so that someone can hear it because all the mics are off.

Ben: Luckily it's a natural amphitheater.

AP: It got to a point where I almost had to be like all right, like that's all — I don't know what to do now.

Ben: And it lasted for a few minutes. I think we got a video, because we lost the soundboard recording but I had my little GoPro on my amp going just for personal recollection of seeing the crowd. So we had to use the audio and video from that and put it together so there is a video where the audio switches to that. But then eventually it pops back on, the amps were on first, I know mine was cycling on for a bit and then we started playing a little bit and then the whole venue comes on and we cut right back in —

AP: To the chorus.

Ben: Oh and yeah, when the power went off the crowd chanted "Water" so like it cut out.

AP: We were going into the chorus, and then when it came back on —

Ben: And then Ben starts going like this. And we had seen the California Honey Drops the night before. If you haven't seen them they were like — went from like a busking band to them like headlining Red Rocks. So they have this very loosey-goosy approach and we'd seen them at Red Rocks the night before and so like it all conspired to be like well here we are, if this is a train wreck you know, we're off the tracks man, let's do it.

MR: Yeah. Lemonade out of lemons.

AP: The moment coming back is, that's the only silver lining is it provides a pretty epic moment when everything does come back together.

Ben: It binds the crowd together too.

MR: Well it seems to me that for like arranging music, when you take something out you miss it, but when you bring it back in it's like, provides this boost that would not have happened if you hadn't taken it out.

Ben There's also, one of Gator's favorite bands is Umphrey's McGee and I've never understood the progressive like, just the proggy, I called it weird or like the [scats] like kind of build up stuff that kind of makes me feel funny inside a little bit, until I thought about those moments where it's like you're creating a group dynamic of us versus them, where everyone feels a little uncomfortable with the music and then you resolve together, so you're kind of building this togetherness as a tribe of awkward-awkward-release. And how we're going out is a similar mindset to that too, it's like oh gosh what's happening? What are we going to do? And then we come back in and it's like ah, we made it through together. It's like bonding in a crisis situation, very low level. And when I realized that, that gave me a whole new understanding and appreciation for tension building in music altogether and how that works en masse.

MR: What were the early days, years of the Pigeons like as far as touring and accommodations and —

AP: Yeah it's definitely gone a long way, I mean Ben can even speak to it even earlier than me but you know when I joined the group you know on one hand it was known that these guys have a lot of momentum and that they're definitely doing well and are going to continue to do well. But it was also very much in that you know initial phase of you know we're all stuffed in our white passenger van. We're setting up, unloading gear all on our own and, you know, doing the full production. And then after the show we split up and we go meet fans and communicate, and hopefully one of them says, "Hey I've got a guest room with, you know, two beds and two couches.

Ben: We would do set breaks. We would call it "divide and conquer." It's like all right, separate, divide and conquer. Now see who you can find if we can have a place to stay.

AP: And Ben can attest, a vast majority of those people that are like, "Yeah I've got plenty of room, come on over," are also, you know they want to hang out, which is fine, but you get there and it's like a tile floor with like a blow-up mattress.

Ben: This was in — it might have been Tuscaloosa or some Alabama town — where we went from one house which was kind of more of a party, and then our drummer wanted a quiet spot — our old drummer — and so he found a spot. And then me and Greg went with this one guy, who was like, "Yeah, I've got some extra space." One of the rooms was the cat litter box room and so the whole — all of the rug was filled with cat litter. Like there was a box somewhere in there and Greg was brave enough to go in there. I laid down in a tiny kitchen. I had to move the giant you know classic like huge trash can, small college

apartment, out of the kitchen and slept there. But on the flip side we've met some of our longest best friends, best fans, who some of them don't really follow us as much as they would before because they have kids now or — a couple of them I'm thinking of had kids at the time and we woke up in the morning and heard these kids running around upstairs and we're like, "Oh you have kids, that's wild." But we've made some of our best connections that way and it was seen, especially early on, as you know get out there and meet the people who are coming out to support you and they'll tell their friends and it's not just about the music it's about the community that you begin to form in each town. And that's one way we did it.

AP: I think that was beneficial. And I think you know a lot of you know what's important is when you are in an upcoming group is kind of you know going through that grind and doing it right and a lot of groups will be so — rightfully so because it is a grind — a lot of groups will be so — will want to jump to that next step too quick where we'll all get our hotel rooms, or we get the tour bus or something, and you know I think to our credit one thing we've done well at is kind of you know treating it in the sense of you know when we graduated to the next point it wasn't like we were all just now getting our own hotel rooms, it went from, you know, find a place to crash to fitting ten guys in one little hotel room and still using the van. You know a lot of groups will kind of just jump to that next step and it can come back and hurt them. And like Ben said even the small things, I think even just connecting with our fans early and kind of you know —

Ben: Or connecting to each other as well.

AP: Yeah going place to place.

Ben: We would share beds and we would get one hotel room for the four of us and that's how it was. And unless we have an odd number of people we always share hotel rooms. We don't get our own rooms as bands, as crew, as anything. I'm usually with the tour manager so I can talk to him about what's coming up. Our sound guys stay together.

AP: You want to be comfortable but you also are not on vacation.

Ben: And again you connect more that way too. If we had our own rooms it's sort of like we'd be all isolated in our own world whereas if we stay together we can kind of stay cohesive as a team. The tour bus is a similar thing where we're together. We don't get hotel rooms unless we have off days on the tour bus.

AP: Unless we have an extended tour — like if we're just playing a smaller run or a weekend run we get back in the white passenger van you know.

MR: Ours was brown.

AP: Yeah, you've got to be smart with your finances and just treat the whole thing like —

Ben: And that's another thing to be aware of. I didn't realize when I first started in a band how much I'd learn about trailer leaf spring axles and it's like oh okay, so this is — you want

to get a tandem axle so you don't break a leaf spring every so often because we're overloading the trailer way too much with this and that. So we learned the hard way in the middle of Indiana having to get axles fused back together in Colorado on the way to Telluride.

MR: Yeah. You get to the end of the week and the band leader says, "Well we blew two speakers this week so your pay will reflect that."

AP: Yeah right.

Ben: Yes so actually you owe us $20.

MR: What is the next — I'll wrap up with a hard question to answer. You're talking about getting from this step to that step, what's the next step for the Pigeons? Do you think ahead like that?

AP: You know definitely I mean on a personal level I think we're definitely all aware of it, some focus on that more than others. But I think in general we're all very aware of that. You know when it comes to the business side and the growth of the band it's hard to say. We're going to continue to just keep doing the things that have gotten us this far and surrounded us with people that have allowed us to continue this journey. I know on a more musical side I think you know we've reached a level over the last couple of years of you know I guess one way you could call it more of a maturity level as far as our playing and trying to sharpen our skills while also like continuing to learn and try new things and I think you know one thing, when we were young and upcoming and playing live is, for me personally, it was always so high energy, gung ho, like everything was just oh, like, and it worked great. Because that's a lot of what our sound is. I think we've kind of taken a step with our writing and kind of the production side of developing songs more with more pocket and you know more like showcasing melody lines as opposed to always just constantly pushing and being high energy. So on the business side I think we just continue to keep doing what we're doing but as far as the musical side I think the last couple of years, especially with you know we have a new record that's coming out in April and I think a lot of that shows kind of a different approach to how we're all fitting into our pieces musically and kind of creating more of a pocket type sound as opposed to — not in a bad way — but as opposed to it used to just be more of a full high energy kind of onslaught, which was great and worked for us as well, but —

Ben: There are a couple of aspects to that question from the business side of things. There's always unexpected things that you never could predict, like Covid. The pandemic. We were kind of cruising up towards growing bigger and bigger. We had done another national headlining tour with our good friends Goose and then the pandemic hit and we kind of settled down. They started working on certain things and hit a moment and they are playing arenas now. And for us the pandemic kind of allowed us to re-look into how

we were growing and approaching it, and you know I wouldn't say it interrupted our growth because it helped re-focus it in a different kind of way, but it did change the trajectory for that period of time and allowed us to kind of look — kind of take the heat off of ourselves and we started writing more together, using remote applications where we can share our music that we still use to this day even though we still practice a couple of times every week when we're home. So that opened up that avenue of writing songs together. And then also, like Gator said, we just love writing music, we love playing music, so we're going to keep writing just constantly. Even those albums coming out, we've written and debuted three —

AP: We've got another couple of albums worth of new tunes.

Ben: Yeah we've debuted three songs in the past couple of months, you know, one New Years — two New Years yeah. And then yeah, just continuing to do that, and then on a slightly more esoteric level from the way I see things, I've always looked at music and my approach and our approach is like taking a microscope and you know like the 5 X or 10 X and you're kind of zoomed in a little bit on the shape of music and you get it centered in the middle and then you jump up to 25 X and then 50 X and 100 X. It's a fractal. So you're going to keep uncovering new shapes as you go in, but you get the general concept of it, and you just zoom in more and clarify it over time. So you're never going to get that final stage but you're going to have it more in focus over time and you're going to be more precise about where you're going as you kind of zoom in and have a more expansive approach to it as a group.

MR: So these two interviews today are going to be a tutorial for those younger musicians who are out — they're down at this level right, and they want to go — so it's very informative and I appreciate your talking about the band and your concepts and it's quite inspiring.

AP: That's much appreciated, to give us an avenue to talk about it.

Ben: And it's an honor to be here amongst such great company of people you've interviewed. Not a day goes by where all of us don't kind of look around like wow, here we are. So that's the other thing to remember is —

MR: Excellent.

Ben: Just you're always enjoying where you're at, even at that small level like there's things to enjoy about laying on a rug with cat litter around you. Don't forget that.

MR: You've come a long way, baby.

AP: Yeah.

MR: Well maybe I'll see you in Utica, New York, my whole family will be there.

Ben: Yeah let us know.

MR: And it will be a gas.

AP: Awesome well thank you so much.

701 MR: All right.

702 Ben: Thanks, Monk.

703 MR: Over and out.